

"In the last decade, gut issues are on the rise. We are finding more cases of constipation...due to the adoption of a western diet, which lacks fibre content. Misuse of antibiotics is also leading to it"

— DR UDAY C. GHOSHAL
President-elect, Indian Society of Gastroenterology

stomach when you are stressed, or experiencing dread, or the rumbling in your stomach at the mere thought of food. A troubled gut leads not just to digestive issues such as diarrhoea and constipation, but can both cause or reflect anxiety, depression or stress. Links are also being established between gut health and autoimmune diseases, endocrine (hormone) conditions, cardiovascular diseases, even cancer.

The Indian Worry

Indians are genetically blessed with a healthy gut microbiome. A 2019 study in the journal *GigaScience*, which compared 1.55 million microbial genes in the Indian gut to those in the global integrated gene catalogue, found that nearly one million previously unlisted genes were unique to our intestines. The genetic legacy apart, the Indian gut also benefited from a diet rich in millets, legumes, fruits and vegetables. Indians also defecate at least once a day, compared to the average figure of three times a week in many developed countries. According to Dr Uday C. Ghoshal, president-elect of the Indian Society of Gastroenterology and the only Indian member of the Rome Foundation, a global body that works to cure gut disorders, the average Indian faeces weighs 311 grams, compared to 200 g in the West. "Because we excrete waste matter in such large volumes, our intestines remain clean. It is why the rate of colon cancer is much lower in India," he says. "Not only is our microbiota robust enough for a very low prevalence of IBS, a debilitating condition, it's also the reason we have better protection against several diseases."

However, unhealthy diets loaded with added sugar, lack of exercise, poor sleep quality and an increasingly sanitised environment, which reduces exposure to 'good' bacteria, may just be depleting the health of the Indian gut fairly rapidly. A 'Gut Health Survey' conducted online in 2023 by the grocery delivery platform Country Delight and the Indian Dietic Association, Mumbai, collected 2,017 responses from Delhi NCR, Mumbai and Bengaluru. Seven out of 10 urban Indians complained of gut health issues. An earlier survey in 2018 by healthcare company Abbott in partnership with market research firm IPSOS surveyed 4,133 Indians in eight cities and found 22 per cent suffering from constipation; of these, 21 per cent reported doing little physical exercise. The two surveys highlight some causes for dysbiosis of the gut, a condition when bacteria are depleted or imbalanced. The 2023 survey found that 63 per cent of the respondents ate junk or processed food. "The once-healthy Indian gut is taking a beating as we abandon local grains and produce, opting instead for heavily refined and processed grain," says celebrity nutritionist Dr Ishi Khosla.

THE BIG 4 GUT DISEASES

1. DIARRHOEA

Diarrhoea, characterised by loose, watery stool, stomach cramps, bloating, nausea, fever, occurs when the gut microbiome undergoes a change in composition, favouring the growth of fast-growing bacteria, such as Proteobacteria and Streptococcus

Causes: Bacterial infections, medications, food intolerances

Treatment: Hydration and maintaining electrolyte balance remain critical. Medicine is used to reduce frequency of stool and treat any underlying stomach infection. Visit a doctor if diarrhoea is severe or chronic

2. CONSTIPATION

Fewer than three bowel movements a week, dry or lumpy stool, pain when passing stool, bloating or loss of appetite are the common symptoms

Causes: While certain antibiotics and illnesses can cause constipation, it is usually the result of reduced intake of fibre and water. Minus fibre, the bacteria in the gut find it difficult to survive; their depletion results in food being undigested/soft enough to pass smoothly

Treatment: Besides medication, increase intake of fibre through fresh fruits/vegetables and whole grains as well as stay hydrated.